—but gradually China had been encroaching upon this region. Ever since China succeeded in establishing a paramount influence at Lhasa, it has been gradually absorbing as much as possible of the border country into its own territory. The result was that over time, large portions of territory that were originally in Tibet and by extension a part of Kham came under the direct control of the viceroys of the neighbouring Chinese provinces. Whilst leaving the native hereditary rulers in actual possession, the Chinese appointed their officials to the various courts to supervise affairs, much in the way the British did by appointing their own residents in the Indian princely states during the Raj.

In the early 1900s, travellers and writers who had visited the region agreed that ethnologically and geographically, Tibet proper extended up to the great Yun-ling Range. The Chinese had maintained their position in Eastern Kham by political adroitness, and only just escaped expulsion owing to the internecine feuds of the numerous petty chieftains and clans. This allowed the Chinese, while holding the Khampas in utter contempt, to maintain an illusion of control over the region and to at least theoretically challenge Lhasa's control over the region.

China's claim on Tibet was a classic case of historical distortion, which was buttressed by the British who double-crossed the Himalayan kingdom in their desire to appease China so that they could further their trade interests. Dismissing Indian arguments on the grounds that post 1947 the Indians were only parroting British imperial policy, the Chinese justified their takeover of Tibet on the grounds that in the twelfth century, Tibet had been briefly incorporated into China when the Mongols under Kublai Khan had established the Yuan Dynasty in China (ad 1271-1368). In reality, the first time China tried to establish political control over Lhasa was in 1720. The Qing Army installed two Chinese resident commissioners (ambans) in Lhasa. For two decades the situation in Tibet had been chaotic ever since the Mongol Lhabsang Khan had notionally assumed the title of King of Tibet in 1697. Around the same time the Tibetan regent, who resented Mongol interference in Tibet, appointed and installed Tsayang Gyatso as the sixth Dalai Lama. Lhabsang Khan accused the new Dalai Lama of 'writing love poems and carousing with women at night in Lhasa'. As relations steadily worsened, Lhabsang Khan, supported by the Qing emperor of China and a number of aristocratic Tibetan families, attacked the regent in